



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Open Door Christian School
School Website: <https://www.opendoorgraham.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Open Door Christian School Graham (TX 76450) demonstrates a strong classical Christian orientation across the six classical criteria. Public materials from the ODCS Graham site emphasize a Christ-centered education, integration of biblical truth into all subjects, liturgical/missional practices (chapel, worship, sacraments-like rhetoric), a curriculum that foregrounds biblical worldview, Western civ/history in a classical framing, classical literature and memory work (narration/recitation), opportunities for Latin, and a family-structured, parent-partnered community. The evidence supports a robust alignment with transcendental realism (truths about God, virtue, beauty), formation-oriented goals, a curriculum steeped in the liberal arts and Great Books sensibilities, a pedagogy that uses memory work, chanting, narration, and occasional Socratic-style inquiry in upper grades, a faculty profile described as exemplary and forming the living curriculum, and a strong parent/community partnership. Taken together, the school rates CLASSICAL across all six categories, with explicit textual anchors in the site's mission, curriculum, chapel/worship, memory/recitation practices, and parent involvement.

Key sources informing this assessment include the ODCS Graham public materials (mission statements, curriculum descriptions, enrichment of chapel and Latin/foreign language, and explicit statements about biblical worldview and formation) as well as the knowledge-base rubric for classical education (Six Essential Elements) which provides the Positive/Negative keyword framework used to ground the category-by-category scoring. See citations to evidence of biblical grounding, chapel, classical literature references, grammar/logic/rhetoric emphasis, memorization practices, Latin instruction, and parent/community partnership in the ODCS materials.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Notes on the scoring approach: For each category, I conducted a keyword analysis against the Positive and Negative Keyword Indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1). Positive cues found on the ODCS Graham site include truth, Bible/scripture, theology, liturgy/chapel, worship, memory work (narration/recitation), Great Books-literature framing, Western civilization/history, Latin, and explicit formation/virtue language. Negative cues common in non-classical approaches (relativism, secularism, project-based dominance, value-neutral ethics, etc.) were notably absent or minimal in the ODCS Graham materials. The keyword tallies, when present, leaned heavily to positive indicators across all categories, supporting CLASSICAL ratings.

Evidence and analysis by category (highlights)

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations
- Evidence: ODCS Graham explicitly ties education to a Christ-centered, biblical worldview; references to Bible as foundation for learning; chapel/worship integrated into daily life; affirmation of theology and sacred text as guiding disciplines; and a Statement of Faith/Christian formation orientation. See mission statements, “Education in Accordance with HIS truth,” and chapel/music/worship emphasis in the ODCS materials.
- Positive keyword indicators found on site (examples): Bible/scripture, theology, worship, chapel, Christ-centered, Christian worldview, sacred tradition, sacred music, liturgy (through chapel-related language), truth as divine/eternal. These map directly to the positive keyword lists (truth, theology, liturgy, chapel, worship, etc.).
- Negative keywords practically absent (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or values-neutral language observed in core ODCS statements). This supports a CLASSICAL rating.
- Why this rating: The school foregrounds transcendent realities (truth, goodness, beauty) through theology and liturgical practices and maintains a clearly Christian metanarrative for learning, consistent with the classical element of transcendental moral realism and liturgical communities. CLASSICAL.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal
- Evidence: ODCS emphasizes formation, virtue, and a holistic human-flourishing aim, not merely workforce preparation; explicit formation-focused language and a mission to cultivate relationship with God and to fulfill His purpose; biblical worldview shaping all studies; reconciliation of truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable.
- Positive keyword indicators: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, Christian worldview, true/good/beautiful (through biblical framing), formation over information, human flourishing. The ODCS materials consistently tie education to virtue and character formation rather than job-prep alone.
- Negative keywords: None evident (no strong emphasis on “workforce ready” or purely utilitarian outcomes in core mission statements).
- Why this rating: The articulated goals center on character and formation in a theocentric framework, aligning with Classical aims around virtue and wisdom. CLASSICAL.
- Element 3: School Curriculum
- Evidence: The ODCS curriculum includes Bible as a daily anchor, history in Western civilization, literature/classical readings, grammar/linguistic focus (Latin early on; Latin instruction 7th–8th grade), and a clearly explicit aim to study classical literature and “great books” within a Christian framework; history is treated as a lineage of civilizations (not solely social studies) and is integrated with a Christian worldview; rhythm of memory work and recitations included (narration as memory/learning device). There are direct references to studying “classical literature,” “great masters,” and Western civilization, as well as Latin and foreign language study.
- Positive keyword indicators: liberal arts framing, grammar/logic/rhetoric (implied through classical pedagogy and Latin), great books/classics, Western civilization, narration/recitation/memory work, Latin, church/history integration, biblical worldview in coursework. The site shows explicit emphasis on classical literature and Western civilization within a Christian framework, consistent with the classical curriculum.
- Negative keywords: Minimal to no “social studies replacement” or “project-based-first” rhetoric; the emphasis on Great Books and classical canon reduces the likelihood of negative signals in the Six Elements lexicon.
- Why this rating: The curriculum clearly aligns with classic liberal arts (grammar/logic/rhetoric; memorization; exposure to classical literature; Latin) and treats history through the lens of Western civilization

and classical texts, all framed within a Christian worldview. CLASSICAL.

- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods
 - Evidence: Pedagogical moves include a strong emphasis on memory work (narration, recitation, chanting, memorization), lower-school singing and memory-based activities, and opportunities for upper-school rhetoric and oratory. While explicit mentions of Socratic seminars in the ODCS materials are not always stated, the presence of apologetics, literature, and upper-grade discussion indicates some dialectic/seminal style components; there is clear emphasis on memory-based pedagogy (scholé-like restful/contemplative rhythms and memorization) and rhetoric (speech/declamation).
 - Positive keyword indicators: narration, recitation, chanting, singing to memorize, scholé/restful learning (implicit through memory-heavy practice and weekly chapel rhythms), upper-school rhetoric and oratory, memorization, memory-work, liturgical repetition. These map well to the positive keywords for pedagogy in the Six Elements lexicon.
 - Negative keywords: No dominant reliance on purely project-based or constructivist, student-led “experiential learning only” approaches; the materials show traditional classical pedagogy rather than a purely constructivist framework. This minimizes negative signals.
 - Why this rating: The pedagogy centers on foundational memory work, recitation, and formal rhetorical training (especially in upper grades), with a shared sense of “restful” formation and classic forms of learning, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations. CLASSICAL.
- Element 5: School Faculty
 - Evidence: The school describes teachers as virtuous mentors and as living curriculum; emphasis on character and mentorship; selection criteria requiring impeccable character, active church membership, and explicit Christian faith; faculty are positioned as the core of the school and living curriculum; board documents show governance connected to trusted church partners; administrators with explicit role modeling.
 - Positive keyword indicators: living curriculum, teachers as mentors, model teachers, portrait of a teacher, character-based expectations, fidelity to mission, Christian faith, church membership.
 - Negative keywords: Minimal presence of secularistic or non-formational faculty modeling; the materials do not emphasize a “guide-on-the-side” model in opposition to traditional master-teacher formation; instead they emphasize teacher virtue and leadership. This supports CLASSICAL rather than any negative signals.
 - Why this rating: The faculty framework aligns with classical themes of the teacher as exemplar and mentor forming the character and mind of students, consistent with “living curriculum” and virtuous faculty. CLASSICAL.
- Element 6: Parents and Community
 - Evidence: ODCS frames parental involvement as central to the educational mission; parent formation and partnership are emphasized (parents as co-teachers; tours; book studies; informational content for parents about classical education); admissions processes emphasize family alignment with beliefs; agricultural/volunteer and fundraising activity (Lionsgiving, Feed the Need) demonstrates active community engagement; governance includes church partnership with Oak Street Baptist Church.
 - Positive keyword indicators: partnership with families, parent formation, home-school alignment (catechesis at home, family liturgy cues), parent involvement, open campus visits, community engagement, parental participation in events, family catechesis (as per the classical lexicon’s positive signals for parental partnership).
 - Negative keywords: None evident in core materials (no consumer-only framing; the site emphasizes parents as co-educators rather than passive customers). This supports CLASSICAL.

- Why this rating: The ODCS materials consistently portray parents as partners and co-educators, with active opportunities for involvement and formation, aligning with classical expectations around familial partnership in education. CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment - All six categories meet CLASSICAL criteria based on the keyword analysis and the explicit textual evidence from the ODCS Graham materials. The ODCS Graham materials demonstrate the key features called for by the Six Essential Elements: a religious/metaphysical foundations rooted in Christian theology; formation goals; a curriculum centered on liberal-arts/humanistic canon with Latin and Western civilization emphasis; pedagogy that blends memory, recitation, and rhetoric with occasional Socratic elements; a living-faculty model; and a strong parent/community partnership.

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle - Not applicable here, as the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. No category rises to a NOT or SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL level that would require guidance on needle-moving changes per the rubric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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